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The Body’s Metaphor: An Anthropological Interpretation of Astarion's Body in Baldur's Gate 3

I chose “Body Scarification and Tattoos” as my course topic and decided to focus my analysis on Astarion from Baldur’s Gate 3 because this theme immediately opened up a dialogue between my personal academic interests and the theoretical perspectives from the course. When I first encountered the topic, the narrative density of Astarion’s bodily marks – the mysterious runic scars on his back and the bite marks on his neck – came to mind at once as an exemplary case through which to think with the course perspective.

Within the game’s narrative, Astarion’s character is shaped through a series of rich bodily metaphors. Both the scars that function as permanent inscriptions of power and the bite marks and blood exchanges that operate as symbols of complex intimacy resonate strongly with the anthropological perspectives we have discussed in class, such as embodiment, multiple bodies, and body substances.

In addition, my ongoing research internship in an “Intimate AI” project has provided an important conceptual background for this perspective. My research focuses on intimate relations between AI and humans, which has led me to engage systematically with Deleuze’s and Marion’s writings on the body, eros, and subjectivity.

In this reflection, I therefore bring together these anthropological theories and Astarion’s fictional body. I focus on his “invisible” face, the forcibly inscribed scars on his back, and the bite marks and blood exchanges whose meanings are renegotiated within relationships. By reading these elements as a form of scarification and tattooing, I aim to offer an anthropological interpretation of how these bodily metaphors mark, respectively, the usurpation, disciplining, and eventual return and reconstruction of his flesh, and how they contribute to his ongoing pursuit of subjectivity.

“Invisible” face: The flesh becoming an object

In Astarion’s story, he has never truly seen his own face after becoming a vampire; he can only describe it as “a dark shape from my past.” This detail immediately reminds me of our course discussions on phenomenology and embodiment. In the readings, the body is often

treated as “the existential ground of culture and self”: from a phenomenological standpoint, the body is the primary self, and our relation to our bodies is not external or detached. As Willerslev points out, we do not have a body as if it were some external possession; rather, we exist as bodies, and the body itself signifies “who I am” (Willerslev 2007: 54). Marion similarly argues that flesh is the originary self itself, and that it is precisely through the “capture” of flesh that the self acquires its initial configuration (Marion 2002: 121–126).

When Astarion’s immediate relation to his own flesh is severed, the very ground of his existence as a sensing and knowing subject begins to tremble. The body then appears in an unnatural way, accompanied by what McDonald describes as a sense of “non-manifestation” and estrangement (McDonald 2018: 188). Through this deprivation, Cazador accomplishes a particularly radical form of control: he not only takes possession of Astarion’s body, but also strips him of the very capacity to be himself. Astarion’s body is no longer the medium through which he accesses the world; instead, it becomes an opaque barrier between him and himself. His subjectivity thus falls into a fundamental emptiness and disorientation, and the body, at this point, is transformed into an object.

The inscription of scars: power, bodily practice, and the shaping of habitus

Building on the systematic deprivation of Astarion’s self-understanding, Cazador completes an extreme form of power-inscription by carving infernal runes into his back. This scar forms a dark resonance with the Kuranko initiation rites we encountered in the course: both cases reveal how power works through bodily practices to engrave norms into flesh and thereby shape individual habitus.

As Foucault argues, the operation of power lies in harnessing, transforming, and disciplining the body (Foucault 1995: 136). Cazador’s actions are a brutal enactment of this mechanism: he turns Astarion’s body into a purely “political body,” whose very meaning is entirely defined and fixed by the master’s will. This scar, like the bodily techniques in Michael Jackson’s account of Kuranko initiation that are meant to instil virtues such as endurance and restraint (for example, prohibitions on speaking or moving), is a form of coercive bodily practice. It bypasses the mediation of language and conceptual knowledge and acts directly on Astarion’s flesh, fully instrumentalising his deprived body and transforming it into a visible and permanent property of power.

This kind of inner mastery achieved through the body finds cross-cultural confirmation in Jackson’s (2014: 253) dialogue with a Kuranko elder. The elder’s statement that “in the fafei

(initiation lodge) you get tamed properly" is, in essence, akin to Cazador's logic. It helps to explain why Astarion can confess: "even in freedom, I never stopped thinking like his slave." The scar, as a forcibly implanted bodily technique, has already shaped his most basic habits and become a persistent "bodily unconscious," so that the shackles of power continue to operate in the depths of his mind even after he has obtained physical freedom.

Bite Marks and Blood: Reconstructing Flesh through Intimate Practice

In sharp contrast to scars that are passively endured, the practices of bite marks and blood exchange become a key arena in which Astarion reconstructs his body and his subjectivity. This process vividly embodies Michael Jackson's insistence that "practice precedes concept": genuine knowing and transformation often occur through bodily actions rather than linguistic articulation (2014: 253).

In Astarion's earlier experiences, biting is a bodily technique disciplined by power, a tool in the service of survival and control. At this stage, his body transmits an alienated signal of "intimacy": bite marks become traces of deception and domination.

The crucial turning point, however, occurs when he refuses the involuntary demand of the blood merchant. Through this bodily decision of "non-action," Astarion establishes a boundary of dignity and autonomy for himself. This refusal is not merely a single act, but a declaration of stance enacted through bodily practice.

On this basis, the symbolic meaning of blood as a "substance of the body" is reconfigured. From an anthropological perspective, blood has consistently functioned as a central symbolic and material resource, running through discussions of kinship, identity and ritual practice(Engelke 2017, pp. 137–160). From the redeeming blood on the cross to the sacred sharing of the Eucharist, blood in different cultural contexts is at once a medium of purification and of connection. When Astarion finally chooses to exchange blood with the protagonist, this act transcends instrumental biting and becomes a ritualized practice of intense intimacy and trust.

At this moment, the bite mark is transformed from a unilateral imprint of power into a bidirectional bond grounded in autonomous choice and mutual recognition. As Marion describes, it is precisely in such mutual perception and reception that two bodies truly open themselves to one another(Marion 2007, pp. 167–70; 2017, pp. 180–183). Astarion's body thus moves from being a passive, dispossessed object to becoming a body full of subjectivity, capable of actively feeling, giving and defining its own meaning.

References

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